

could arrange a new marriage for Placidia. The elevation of a throne claimant beholden to the Vandals, whose support would have come from the followers of Licinia Eudoxia, could have been presented by Geiseric in the West as well as in the East as an "advocate of the empire" and furthermore could have been of great benefit for the future. When Alaric's Visigoths had captured Rome forty-five years earlier, they had elevated Priscus Attalus as their "own" Augustus, and Theoderic intended to take a similar step with Avitus as early as 456. But while Attalus and Avitus lacked effective backing in Italy, Geiseric had the chance to legitimize his candidate through a marriage connection with the ruling dynasty of many decades. The plundering of Rome and the capture of the empress dowager with her daughters instead make it clear that the Vandalic king at this time was not yet pursuing the grand and long-term plans Wirth attributes to him. According to Priscus, the murder of Valentinian III and the subsequent unrest in Rome primarily provided an immediate opportunity for Geiseric to strengthen his own position. The king was certainly well informed about the events, even without direct contact with Licinia Eudoxia or her entourage, and knew that given the division in the Roman army, no serious military resistance was to be feared. This applied all the more to the kind of coup attempts that the Vandals had already carried out several times with astonishing success. The fact that the treaty of 442, which had been suspended by Valentinian's death and probably not re-confirmed by Petronius Maximus, could also be interpreted as a hostile act and thus justify the Vandalic intentions. After Geiseric had taken Rome as planned, he removed everything from the city that could be considered valuable in any way. This naturally included minted and unminted precious metal, but also prominent captives. The empress dowager, her two daughters, Aetius' son Gaudentius, and several senators were for Geiseric not only potential sources of ransom, but primarily a political bargaining chip of inestimable value. Even without further plans,

51. Regarding Alaric, cf. Demandt, 1989, p. 144 f., regarding Avitus below VIII.1.2.

52. Prisc. frg. 30,1 J. Antiochi. frg. 201,6: Καὶ Γίζριχος τὸν Βανδάλων ἄρχων τῆς ἐτῆς καὶ Βαλεντινιανῆς λυθεῖσαν ἐπικολῶν πειθεσθαι τὰς τάλαις καὶ τὴν ἡγεσμένον, ὅς τις μὲν ἐρῆνης θανάτῳ τὴν σπείσασιν λυθείσης, τοῦ δὲ ἐπὶ βασιλεῖαν παρελθόντος μὲν ξίχρεων κεκτημένου δόναμιν...

53. According to Priscus, the army was divided over Valentinian's succession (s.o.). – O'Flynn, 1983, p. 180 fn. 12, suggests a collaboration between Geiseric and Licinia Eudoxia, because "... the imperial ladies could have escaped from Rome prior to Geiseric's arrival had they seriously wished to do so." A voluntary stay in Rome might provide clues to Licinia Eudoxia's own view of things, but not necessarily to Geiseric's intentions. Whether there were points of contact here is uncertain.

54. As with their crossing to Africa in 429 or the capture of Carthage ten years later. Similar actions also led to successes for Geiseric in 460 against Majorian and in 468 against the East Roman fleet. Cf. below VIII.3.2.

55. Cf. Prisc. frg. 30,1 (s.o. fn. 52). Seeck, 1920, p. 324; Schmidt, 1942, p. 77 f.

56. PLRE II s.v. Gaudentius 7. Anicius Olybrius, however, Placidia's fiancé, escaped a similar fate, because he was in Constantinople in 455. Max, 1975, S. 63; Clover, 1978, S. 176–179.

to pursue them, this consideration alone might have sufficiently motivated the Vandal attack. That Geiseric understood himself in 455 beyond that as a protector of the Theodosian house and an advocate of a legitimist idea is, however, more than uncertain. The result of the roughly nine months between September 454 and June 455 proved to be a disaster for the Roman side: two emperors had been murdered. The dynasty, which had ruled for over sixty years, was ended and the throne was thus vacant; the city plundered, the provinces restless, the previous consensus within the senatorial aristocracy irrevocably damaged. The crisis of 454/5 had created problems that were to burden the Western Roman Empire for decades.

57. That Geiseric primarily wanted to make spoils, as Proc. BV I 5,1 claims, is rejected by Clover, 1966, S. 145 f., and explained as a reflection of the impression left by the autopsy of the treasures of 455 eighty years later by Procopius. On the other hand, Courtois, 1955, S. 196, who, with Gautier, 1937, S. 238, considers the conquest of Rome as "une magnifique entreprise de piraterie sur une très grande échelle, une affaire exceptionnellement fructueuse" apparently hits reality.

58. Eastern authors therefore later saw the murder of Aetius as the beginning of the end: Marc. Com. s.a. 454,2 = Chron. Min. II, S. 86: cum ipso (sc. Aetio) Hesperium cecidit regnum nec hactenus valuit relevari (according to Paul. Diac. hist. Rom. XIV 15). Similarly Proc. BV I 4,28; Prisc. frg. 30,1 = J. Antioch. frg. 201,2 f. Marcellinus probably only reflects a tradition within the Anician historiography (so Momigliano, 1956, S. 235 f.; Wes, 1967, S. 110–116 u. 170–173; Zecchini, 1981, S. 124). Priscus and Procopius, following him, show, however, that the death of Aetius was understood as an overall Roman loss also outside the Anicii.